

> Hardening Email Sender Authentication: A Lab-Based Evaluation of SPF/DKIM/DMARC Misconfigurations

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> Introduction

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> Why Email Spoofing Still Works

Problem

Phishing campaigns still succeed because email sender authentication is often misconfigured or only partially deployed.

Attackers can impersonate trusted identities even when some authentication mechanisms seem to be enabled.

Project Goal

Build a controlled lab to reproduce spoofing attacks.

Systematically analyze how SPF, DKIM and DMARC misconfigurations affect spoofing success and how to fix them.

> Research Questions & Contributions

Preliminary Studies

Under which SPF, DKIM and DMARC configurations does spoofing still succeed?

How do protocol composition flaws (e.g., relaxed alignment, parser inconsistencies) impact authentication?

Can SMTP artefacts be used to detect spoofed emails automatically?

Development Contributions

Docker-based lab for sender-authentication experiments.

Systematic exploration of SPF/DKIM/DMARC misconfigurations.

Evaluation of infrastructure hardening and ML-based detection.

> Experimental Workflow

Project Development

Infrastructure setup: Docker, BIND, Postfix/Dovecot, webmail.

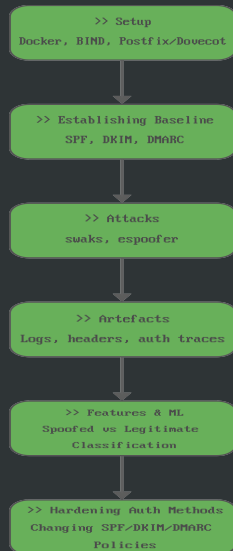
Authentication baseline: SPF, DKIM, DMARC behaviour.

Spoofing attacks: swaks, espoofer, custom scripts.

SMTP artefact collection: logs, headers, authentication traces.

Feature extraction and ML-based spoofing detection.

Infrastructure hardening and re-evaluation.



```
> Development Highlights:  spoofmaster
```

Helper tool to orchestrate spoofing tests inside the lab.

Wraps `attack.sh` script using `swaks` - aka. Swiss Army Knife.

Produces artefacts later used for ML-based detection.

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** Welcome to SpoofMaster - SPF/DKIM/DMARC Bypass Demo - SEED Labs **
```

> Lab Architecture

Isolated Docker network with four main containers:

- DNS server (BIND) hosting SPF/DKIM/DMARC records.

- Victim mail server (Postfix + Dovecot).

- Attacker container running swaks and Espoofer.

- Webmail client for victim-side inspection.

No connectivity to the real Internet to keep attacks contained.

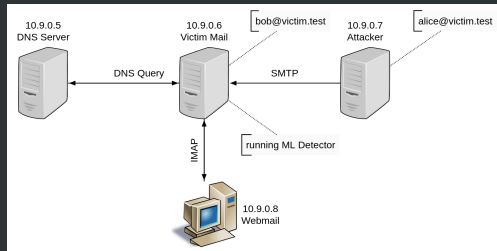


Figure: Docker-based isolated mail infrastructure

> Authentication Protocols

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Roles

SPF validates the sending IP against the domain in the SMTP envelope (MAIL FROM).

DKIM attaches a cryptographic signature that covers selected headers and body.

DMARC combines SPF/DKIM results and enforces domain alignment and policy.

Key Insight

Authentication does not automatically mean security: misconfiguration or weak policies can still allow spoofed messages to be delivered.

> Where Misconfigurations Appear

Examples from the Lab

[Diagram: DNS records vs. MTA configuration vs. headers]

SPF: v=spf1 mx all| (soft-fail, accepts suspicious senders).

DKIM: selector not published or key mismatch.

DMARC: v=DMARC1; p=none; aspf=r; adkim=r| (monitoring only, relaxed alignment).

Impact

Suspicious mail is accepted or only logged.

Spoofed visible identities are not blocked.

> Spoofing Attacks

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> SPF-Based Spoofing Scenario

Attack Setup

SPF configured with soft-fail (all|) and permissive host entries.

Attacker sends mail using swaks with:

Envelope sender: attacker@attacker.test.

Visible From: header: Alice <alice@victim.test>.

Observation

SPF can pass because the envelope sender is allowed.

The user still sees a spoofed identity in the visible From header.

> Advanced Authentication Bypass (espoofer)

Attack Goal

Exploit composition flaws and parser inconsistencies to bypass SPF, DKIM and DMARC simultaneously.

Techniques

Carefully crafting multiple From headers.

Taking advantage of relaxed alignment and inconsistent header parsing.

Using Espoofer to automate complex SMTP interactions.

Result

Spoofed emails can still be delivered even though all three mechanisms appear to be deployed.

> Analysis and Detection

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Collected Artefacts

Authentication-Results headers (SPF, DKIM, DMARC outcomes).

Mail logs from the victim mail server and DNS logs from BIND.

Header anomalies (multiple From, inconsistent domains).

Purpose

Understand why specific messages pass or fail authentication (e.g., DKIM selector not found vs. signature mismatch).

Transform artefacts into features for ML-based detection.

Feature Engineering

- Authentication outcomes (SPF, DKIM, DMARC).

- Domain alignment indicators (match/mismatch).

- Header and path anomalies derived from SMTP traces.

Classifier Role

- Distinguish legitimate vs. spoofed emails even under weak policies.

- Act as a final defensive layer when protocol-level checks are bypassed.

> Results and Hardening

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> Infrastructure Hardening

Before (Vulnerable)

SPF: soft-fail, permissive includes.

DKIM: keys not published or misconfigured.

DMARC: policy p=none, relaxed alignment.

After (Hardened)

SPF: strict -all| and limited authorized hosts.

DKIM: properly published selector and validated key.

DMARC: p=reject| with strict alignment for SPF and DKIM.

Spoofing Success vs. Configuration

No authentication or very weak policies: attacks consistently succeed.

SPF-only or DMARC with monitoring: many spoofed emails still delivered.

Fully hardened SPF/DKIM/DMARC: tested attacks are blocked or flagged by ML.

Key Observation

Defence-in-depth and correct protocol composition are required; each mechanism alone is insufficient.

Key Lessons

- Misconfiguration and weak composition of SPF, DKIM and DMARC make spoofing feasible.
- Reproducible infrastructure allows safe experimentation and clear hardening guidelines.
- ML-based detection complements protocol-level authentication.

Future Work

- Extend the lab with more diverse real-world configurations and datasets.
- Refine DKIM/DMARC handling and detection features.
- Explore usability aspects and deployment recommendations.

> References

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